IT Acceptable Use Policy

Effective Date: January 1, 2025
Version: 2.0

1. Purpose and Scope

This Information Technology Acceptable Use Policy establishes guidelines for the appropriate use of company IT resources, including computers, networks, email systems, internet access, and company data. This policy applies to all employees, contractors, consultants, temporary workers, and other personnel who have access to company IT resources.

2. General Usage Guidelines

2.1 Authorized Use

- IT resources are provided for business purposes to support company operations
- Limited personal use is permitted during breaks if it doesn't interfere with work responsibilities
- All usage must comply with local, state, and federal laws
- Users must respect intellectual property rights and licensing agreements

2.2 Prohibited Activities

Users must NOT:

- Share login credentials or passwords with anyone
- Access another user's files without explicit authorization
- Install unauthorized software or applications
- Use company resources for personal financial gain
- Stream non-work related video content during business hours
- Connect personal devices to the network without IT approval
- Disable or bypass security software
- Send chain letters, spam, or solicitations

3. Password and Access Security

3.1 Password Requirements

All passwords must:

- Be at least 12 characters long
- Include uppercase and lowercase letters
- Contain at least one number and one special character
- Be changed every 90 days
- Be unique and not reused for 12 cycles
- Never be written down or stored in plain text

3.2 Account Security

- Lock your workstation when stepping away (Windows+L or Ctrl+Alt+Del)
- Report any suspected security breach immediately to IT

- Never leave laptops or mobile devices unattended in public places
- Use two-factor authentication when available

4. Email and Communication

4.1 Professional Communication

- All email communications must be professional and courteous
- Include appropriate subject lines and signatures
- Use "Reply All" sparingly and only when necessary
- Check recipient lists carefully before sending sensitive information

4.2 Email Security

- Never open suspicious attachments or links
- Report phishing attempts to security@company.com immediately
- Do not forward company emails to personal email accounts
- Encrypt emails containing sensitive or confidential data
- Delete emails according to the company retention policy

5. Internet and Network Usage

5.1 Appropriate Internet Use

- Internet access is primarily for business purposes
- Research and professional development activities are encouraged
- Personal browsing should be minimal and during break times only

5.2 Restricted Content

The following content is strictly prohibited:

- Adult or sexually explicit material
- Gambling or gaming websites
- Illegal downloads or pirated software
- Hate speech or discriminatory content
- Websites that pose security risks

5.3 Downloads and Installations

- Only download files from trusted sources
- All software must be approved by IT before installation
- Report any accidental downloads of suspicious files immediately
- Keep all software updated with latest security patches

6. Data Protection and Confidentiality

6.1 Data Classification

- PUBLIC: Information intended for public distribution
- INTERNAL: General business information for internal use
- CONFIDENTIAL: Sensitive business data requiring protection

- RESTRICTED: Highly sensitive data with strict access controls

6.2 Data Handling Requirements

- Store all company data on approved network drives or cloud storage
- Never save sensitive data to personal devices or cloud accounts
- Use encryption for all portable media containing company data
- Shred physical documents containing sensitive information
- Report any data loss or exposure incidents within 2 hours

6.3 Customer Data Protection

- Access customer data only when necessary for job duties
- Never share customer information outside the organization
- Follow all privacy regulations including GDPR and CCPA
- Complete annual data protection training

7. Mobile Device and Remote Work

7.1 Company-Issued Devices

- Keep devices password-protected and encrypted
- Install all required security updates promptly
- Report lost or stolen devices immediately (within 1 hour)
- Return all devices upon termination of employment

7.2 Personal Device Usage (BYOD)

- Register personal devices with IT before connecting to company resources
- Install required mobile device management (MDM) software
- Accept that company may remote-wipe device if compromised
- Keep personal and work data separated

7.3 Remote Access

- Use only approved VPN connections for remote access
- Never use public WiFi without VPN protection
- Ensure home networks are password-protected
- Follow clean desk policy even when working from home

8. Social Media and Online Presence

8.1 Professional Conduct

- Do not disclose confidential company information on social media
- Include disclaimers when discussing work-related topics
- Be respectful and professional in all online interactions
- Do not claim to represent the company unless authorized

8.2 Company Reputation

- Think before posting anything that could reflect on the company

- Report any negative mentions of the company to Marketing/PR
- Do not engage with trolls or hostile commenters
- Follow the company's social media guidelines

9. Software and Licensing

9.1 Licensed Software

- Use only properly licensed software
- Do not make unauthorized copies of software
- Report any licensing concerns to IT immediately
- Complete software audits as requested

9.2 Cloud Services

- Use only IT-approved cloud storage and collaboration tools
- Never upload company data to personal cloud accounts
- Enable two-factor authentication on all cloud services
- Review sharing permissions regularly

10. Incident Response

10.1 Security Incidents

If you suspect a security incident:

1. Disconnect affected device from network if safe to do so
2. Contact IT Security immediately at ext. 5555
3. Preserve all evidence and do not attempt fixes
4. Document everything you observed
5. Await instructions from IT Security team

10.2 Required Reporting

Report the following immediately:

- Suspected malware or virus infections
- Phishing or social engineering attempts
- Unauthorized access attempts
- Lost or stolen devices
- Data breaches or exposures
- Unusual system behavior

11. Physical Security

11.1 Workspace Security

- Lock drawers and cabinets containing sensitive materials
- Use privacy screens in open office environments
- Position monitors away from public view
- Secure all devices with cable locks when applicable

11.2 Visitor Management

- Never allow unauthorized persons to tailgate through secure doors
- Challenge unknown individuals in restricted areas
- Ensure visitors are properly escorted
- Report suspicious behavior to Security

12. Compliance and Monitoring

12.1 Monitoring Notice

- The company reserves the right to monitor all IT resource usage
- No expectation of privacy exists on company systems
- All data on company devices is subject to search
- Monitoring is conducted to ensure security and policy compliance

12.2 Compliance Requirements

- Complete all required security training within 30 days
- Acknowledge this policy annually
- Cooperate with security audits and investigations
- Report policy violations by others when observed

13. Consequences of Policy Violations

13.1 Disciplinary Actions

Violations of this policy may result in:

- Verbal or written warnings
- Temporary suspension of access privileges
- Termination of employment
- Legal action for serious violations
- Personal liability for damages caused

13.2 Severity Levels

- MINOR: First-time, unintentional violations with minimal impact
- MODERATE: Repeated violations or those causing disruption
- SEVERE: Intentional violations, data breaches, or illegal activities

14. Training and Awareness

14.1 Required Training

All users must complete:

- Initial IT security awareness training within 30 days of hire
- Annual refresher training
- Phishing simulation exercises quarterly
- Role-specific training as assigned

14.2 Resources

- IT Help Desk: helpdesk@company.com or ext. 4357
- Security Team: security@company.com or ext. 5555
- Policy Questions: compliance@company.com
- Training Portal: training.company.com

15. Policy Maintenance

15.1 Review Schedule

- This policy will be reviewed annually
- Updates will be communicated via email
- Major changes require re-acknowledgment

15.2 Feedback and Suggestions

- Submit suggestions to itpolicy@company.com
- Participate in annual policy effectiveness surveys
- Report unclear or conflicting requirements

Acknowledgment

By accessing company IT resources, you acknowledge that you have read, understood, and agree to comply with this IT Acceptable Use Policy. You understand that violations may result in disciplinary action up to and including termination of employment.

Appendix A: Quick Reference

DO's:

✓ Lock your computer when away
✓ Report security incidents immediately
✓ Use strong, unique passwords
✓ Keep software updated
✓ Think before you click
✓ Protect company data
✓ Follow clean desk policy
✓ Complete required training

DON'Ts:

✗ Share passwords
✗ Click suspicious links
✗ Install unauthorized software
✗ Save data to personal accounts
✗ Use public WiFi without VPN
✗ Ignore security warnings

✗ Leave devices unattended
✗ Violate licensing agreements

Appendix B: Contact Information

IT Help Desk

- Phone: ext. 4357 (HELP)
- Email: helpdesk@company.com
- Hours: Monday-Friday, 7:00 AM - 7:00 PM

IT Security Team

- Phone: ext. 5555
- Email: security@company.com
- Emergency: Available 24/7

Compliance Office

- Phone: ext. 2677
- Email: compliance@company.com
- Hours: Monday-Friday, 8:00 AM - 5:00 PM

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